

Developing your idea

Having picked your idea and decided to back it as an innovation project, you now have the challenge of turning it into a real product, service, or process for people. This is where you need to put in place structures and systems to help manage projects effectively. But it's not just managing in terms of resources and budgets—there is also the challenge of uncertainty.

TIP

BE FLEXIBLE

Allow sufficient flexibility in the system for small, fast-track projects to take place.

Managing the process

In innovation there is no such thing as guaranteed success—you might find out after you start that the technology that looked so exciting at the start actually doesn't work or do what you want it to do. Or else you might find that the market you thought was there for your new idea actually isn't that interested. Or maybe a competitor has come up on your blind side and offered something better. Or the government has changed the rules of the game on you. Or some other unexpected thing has happened—remember Murphy's Law—if something can go wrong it probably will.

All of this means that you need to have good project-management practices as your innovation develops, and also the flexibility to review and change your projects—to cancel those that are going nowhere, to modify others to meet changes in circumstances, and to continue to support only those that look like they are really going to produce real benefits. You need a project management system that regularly reviews the status of projects, identifies the risks associated with progressing them further, and only allocates additional resources to those projects that still meet strategic criteria and have a high probability of success.

